UNIT 4 MASS COMMUNICATION RESEARCH: PRINCIPLES AND PROCESS

Structure

4.0 INTRODUCTION

This unit is very important for understanding how the process of research is to be conducted in the discipline of mass communication. The unit explains the various aspects of mass communication research by breaking it down into different core sections which explain in detail about the process that is followed in conducting research and what type of techniques and instruments are to be utilized for specific research objectives.

The unit will help in developing a conceptual understanding about both qualitative and quantitative approaches to research and when and how they are applicable in mass communication research. In addition to that, the unit will help you realise that mere conduct of research is not enough. There are certain ethical principles to be followed too.

We shall now discuss this unit in detail. We shall start with the development of mass media research, objectives of research and other important topics.

4.1 LEARNING OUTCOMES

After reading through this unit, you should be able:

- discuss the principles and process of mass communication research;
- develop scientific approach to mass communication research;

- describe the types of research and steps involved in the research process
- develop a research report
- differentiate between research method and methodology
- appreciate the importance of ethics in research

4.2 MASS COMMUNICATION RESEARCH: PRINCIPLES AND PROCESS

With the mass media spreading its wings wide and growing by leaps and bounds, research in this field is also becoming immensely popular. The whole world rests on the process of communication. With the expansion of technology, research in mass communication has shown an immense growth all over the world. From Nautanki to street plays to print media like books, newspapers, magazines and electronic media like radio and T.V. have shown a great reach. The new media due to rapid growth of internet has also proved to be a significant medium in brining mass mobilization and spurring the masses. Thus, research in the field of mass communication is gathering both popularity and significance. There are private research agencies both in India and abroad doing research on various aspects of media.

As the content generated is getting specific with niche readers and viewers, the advertisers have better chances to reach their target audiences. For this, they require accurate research to be implemented.

Merriam-Webster dictionary describes "research" as "studious inquiry or examination especially investigation or experimentation aimed at discovery and interpretation of facts, revision of accepted theories or laws in the light of new facts or practical application of such new or revised theories or laws". Advance Learner dictionary defines research as a careful investigation or enquiry for the search for new facts in any branch of knowledge. Reddman and Mory define research as a systematized effort to gain new knowledge. Research is also defined as the scientific and systematic search for pertinenent knowledge. Research is the art of scientific investigation.

4.2.1 Development of Mass Media Research

There were four major events that led to the development of the mass media research:

1) The World War I- Propaganda studies researchers worked from a stimulus response point of view that attempted to uncover effects of media on people (Lasswell, 1927). There was a need to understand the nature of propaganda by using the media and media had a huge impact on the people. Assumptions were being made and research was on a firm foundation.
2) Realization by the advertisers in 1950's and 1960's – In this stage, research data was used to persuade potential customers to buy products and services. The advertisers used research studies to know their target audience in a better way and reach them using an effective medium.
3) Increasing interest of the citizens in the effects of media on public:- At this stage, subjects that garmered greater interest included violence and sexual content in TV shows for children. Both the negative and positive effects of it were being studied.
4) Increasing competition among media organizations:- Competition for the audience and advertising revenue further increased the pace of the mass media

research. The audience was being segmented into groups and content created had different niches. The advertisers wanted to know the demographics and psychographics of these chunks of audience for which researchers had to work.

4.2.2 Objectives of Research

The purpose of research is to discover answers to questions by the application of scientific procedures and to make oneself acquainted with the occurrence to garner new insights. These studies are termed as exploratory research.

The research which can be used to portray the characteristic of either an individual or a group is called descriptive research. When casual relationship between variables is studied, it is called hypothesis testing.

4.2.3 Motivation in Research

The fundamental importance is what makes people undertake research. A few factors promoting motivation in research are given below:

1. It will help the researcher to get a research degree along with the consequential benefits of the research.
2. It helps invoke interest in facing the challenges in solving the problems that are unsolved.
3. Research brings an intellectual joy of doing some creative work.
4. The research conducted will be of service to the society and beneficial for the people.
5. The directives of government also motivate people to perform research and the researcher earns great respect for his/her work.

4.3 SCIENTIFIC APPROACH IN MASS COMMUNICATION RESEARCH

4.3.1 Steps in Scientific Research

Scientific method is closely related to the Webster dictionary meaning of the word "research". A scientific research method involves an organized objective, controlled, qualitative or quantitative empirical analysis of one or more variables. The four steps of scientific method are:

4.3.2 Theories

A theory is an explanation that is proposed for how certain natural phenomena occur which can make a prediction about the phenomena for the future as well as can be falsified by empirical observations (West & Turner, 2006). The theories based on the topic of research are properly read upon by the researcher to come to a theory which must be backed by proper scientific support, data, results and replications.

4.3.3 Predictions (Hypotheses)

A hypothesis is an idea suggested to be an explanation for particular conditions but which is not yet proved to be correct (Collins dictionary). Sets of propositions are formulated to reach an argument and form a logical conclusion. This is done on the basis of syllogism where from a set of premises and a conclusion is reached. However, for a conclusion to be correct, the premises must be true.

4.3.4 Observations

In this part of scientific method, the researcher tests the hypotheses formulated during the previous step. Unlike physical sciences, testing hypotheses in social sciences is difficult, simply because the humans provide multiple possibilities to the social science researchers. There are certain processes although that can help remove the errors and uncertainties to a certain extent. The researchers must be empirical and objective while noting the observations for which certain tools are used.

4.3.5 Empirical Generalizations

This is the final stage of scientific method where a phenomenon is described based upon the knowledge of the phenomenon at that point of time. These empirical generalisations are based on the observations made in the previous step. At times, a hypothesis may become true and at times false. This must be done with honesty in research findings or the quality of research may suffer.

Check Your Progress 1

Note: 1) Use the space provided below for your Answers.
2) Compare your answers with those given at the end of the unit.

1. What do you understand by hypothesis?

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2. What is empirical generalisation? Why should it be done with honesty?

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3. Explain the importance of objectives in research?

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4.4 TYPES OF RESEARCH

Come of the basic categories of research are:

4.4.1 Descriptive/Analytical Research

Descriptive research involves survey and enquiries to find facts of different kinds. The foremost function of this research is to give a detailed description of the state of the affairs regarding those that exist currently. The main characteristic of this research is that the researcher has no control whatsoever over the variables and he can only report the happenings. The research methods applied here basically are different types of survey methods including the comparative and co-relational methods

In analytical research, the facts and information already available are analyzed to make a critical evaluation.

4.4.2 Applied/Action/Fundamental (basic) Research

Applied research or action research is aimed to find a solution for a problem in the society or an organization. Certain examples of applied research are those to identify social, economic or political trends, marketing research and evaluation research. It aims to find a solution for an existing problem.

Fundamental research or basic research relates to generalizations or formulation of theories Research in any kind of natural phenomena, human behaviours or related to pure mathematics are fundamental or pure research. It aims to gather knowledge for the sake of knowledge. It has a broad base of applications and is directed towards finding information to add to the already existing mass of knowledge.

4.4.3 Quantitative/Qualitative

Quantitative research is based on quantitative data i.e. measurement of quantity or amount. All phenomena that are expressed in quantity come under this type of research

Qualitative research deals with qualitative phenomena like finding reasons for human behavior. It aims to discover underlying desires and motives with the help of in-depth interviews. Other techniques include story completing tests, sentence completing tests, word association tests among others.

Attitude or opinion research is also qualitative research where research aims to find out what people think about a particular topic or an institution. This research helps find out reasons or factors of liking or disliking a particular thing by the people. Practicing this type of research is difficult and requires guidance from expert researchers.

4.4.4 Conceptual/ Empirical

Conceptual research relates to an abstract idea(s) or theory. This type of research is generally used by thinkers or philosophers to formulate new concepts or reinterpret the earlier ones.

Empirical research depends on the experiences and observations irrespective of the system and the theory. It can be also called as experimental type of research as it is based on the data, reaching conclusions that are verifiable by observation and conclusion. The data, in empirical research, needs to be collected first hand from the source. He must have with himself a working hypothesis and then gather enough facts to prove or disprove it. This type of research is done through surveys and/or observations. The researcher has control over the variables under study and he may deliberately manipulate one of them to study the effects on others. Besides, there may be other types of research and can be defined as onetime research and longitudinal research. These types of researches are classified on the basis of time period selected. This research is restricted to a solitary fixed time period while longitudinal research is carried out over a larger time period.

Field setting research and laboratory research. This classification is made on the basis of the place where the research is carried out.

4.4.5 Clinical/Diagnostic/Exploratory Research

These types of research go for case-study methods to reach the causes of events or happenings. A small sample is taken and deep probing is done to gather the data. An exploratory research develops a hypothesis rather than tests it while a formalized research has a proper structure to test the hypotheses.

4.5 RESEARCH APPROACHES

The types of research given above reveal that there are basically two approaches to research namely:

4.5.1 Quantitative Approach

This approach involves quantitative data which is subjected to rigorous analysis in a formal procedure. It can be further classified into following categories:

In inferential approach, survey research is done through which a sample of population is studied to infer or conclude certain characteristics or relationships of the population

In experimental approach, certain variables are manipulated to observe their effect on other variables and thus exercising greater control over the research environment

Simulation approach creates an artificial environment where data can be generated and relevant information can be studied. This allows observing dynamic behavior of the system under controlled conditions. Simulation refers to the operation of a numerical model within a dynamic process.

4.5.2 Qualitative Approach

This approach involves the subjective study of attitudes, opinions and behaviours where the researcher works according to his insights and impressions. This is done through focus group interviews and depth interviews and the results are not subjected to rigorous quantitative analysis.

Check Your Progress 2

Note: 1) Use the space provided below for your Answers.
2) Compare your answers with those given at the end of the unit.

1. What is the difference between applied and fundamental research? Which research will help in the development of theories?

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2. What is the difference between the quantitative and qualitative approaches to research?

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4.6 STEPS INVOLVED IN A RESEARCH PROCESS

Research consumes both time and money. Since time and money are highly valuable, research must be carried out in a proper process. The eight steps involved in a typical research process are:

1) Selection of a problem
2) Review of existing research studies and theories
3) Development of hypotheses and/or research questions
4) Deciding an appropriate methodology/ research design
5) Collection of relevant data
6) Analysis and interpretation of the results
7) Presentation of the results in an appropriate form
8) Replication of the study (when necessary)

All the above steps help to reach a maximally efficient research study. For instance, the researcher must a clearly state the research problem before the review of literature is done; the researcher must know the types of studies already conducted to design the most efficient method of investigating a problem etc. In addition, all the steps are interactive as review of literature may refine or even alter the initial research problem; a study conducted before may expedite (or complicate) the current research effort Step by step procedure of research The steps involved in a mass communication research project are given below.

4.7 SELECTION OF THE TOPIC

Step 1: Selection of the topic: The topic selected for research must be thought over carefully keeping the following aspects in mind:

4.7.1 Relevance

The topic must hold relevance in the existing scenario. Its significance is a crucial aspect when starting the research. There are topics upon which immense research are done like effects of violence in movies on children or celebrity endorsements in advertising. Thus, research on such topics would not make sense and instead doing research on current and new topics would be helpful.

4.7.2 Feasibility

The second aspect when selecting a topic for research is its feasibility which means whether the research would be accomplished during the time period set or for that matter, despite many other physical constraints. Like being located in Kashmir, it would not be feasible enough to do research on the coverage of Tsunami in Tamil Nadu or Andaman Broadness.

4.7.3 Broadness

Depending upon the purpose of research project, the Broadness of the topic is decided. For example, if you reach a topic for research which is online advertising, it is way too broad to do research. Depending upon whether the research is a minor project or a major project, the topic is crystallized and decided.

4.7.4 Time and Cost Constraints

Time and cost are important aspects to think of when selecting a topic for research.

4.8 RETRIEVING INFORMATION AND REVIEW

After deciding the topic of research, an in-depth reading of the text related to the topic follows. Review of literature is done on the topic chosen for the research for proper understanding of the topic and the already done research on the topic. There are different types of information sources that can be scanned to get the required information. These include scholarly research journals, books, magazines, newspapers, encyclopedias and handbooks, blogs and websites on the internet.

All the information sources must be cited properly and proper citations to the information must be given. Following things must be kept in mind before going ahead:

1) Types of previous research in the similar area.
2) Results and conclusions of previous studies.
3) Suggestions by researchers for future studies.
4) Some aspects that have not been investigated.
5) Contribution of the proposed study to the knowledge of that area of research methods that were used earlier.

Looking at previous research studies, the researcher can decide what perspective the stuying does not have so that s/he may follow a different methodology and derive results. After proper reading of the present sources of information, specific hypotheses and research questions are defined.

4.9 STATING HYPOTHESIS AND RESEARCH QUESTIONS/OBJECTIVES

Specific hypotheses and research questions or objectives are framed keeping in mind the topic of research. A hypothesis as already mentioned is a formal statement that has not been tested yet. It states the relationship between variables and is tested directly. The predicted relationship between the variables is either true or false. While a research question is a formally stated question that provides indications about something. Unlike hypothesis, it is not limited to investigating relationships between variables. Research questions or the objectives define the aim of the study in the general area of investigation. The information used to draft the research questions helps in testing the hypothesis later in the study.

4.10 PREPARATION OF RESEARCH

Research design means the conceptual structure within which a research study is conducted. Depending upon the purposes of research, research design is prepared which results in getting maximum information and evidences in less time, money and effort.

4.10.1 Exploratory Design

The exploratory design involves exploring the new concepts or theories i.e. digging deep into the problem to reach a particular conclusion. In this design, many aspects of the problem are to be considered and a flexible research design is to be formed.

4.10.2 Descriptive Design

It involves the description of a problem or an event. The design must minimize the biases and maximize the reliability of data collected and analysed.

4.10.3 Diagnostic Design

This type of research design takes a small sample and studies it on the basis of several parameters. The reasons, causes and factors regarding a particular problem or an event are studied by the collection of the data and its analysis.

4.10.4 Experimental Design

These experimental designs can be informal or formal designs and involves huge amount of money for the laboratory set-up. This is the most difficult type of research design to be practiced.

4.11 RESEARCH METHODOLOGY VS RESEARCH METHODS

The words methodology and methods are often confused with each other. Methodology is the study of methods and the groundwork philosophical assumptions of the research process itself. Different research questions will have different methodologies. If a researcher is interested in how the Internet is affecting the copyright laws, he or she would probably choose the methodology of legal research. If a researcher wants to trace how radio programming has evolved since the introduction of television, he may choose historical methodology. A study about the effects of television on children may use scientific methodology

In short; methodology deals with the question of "why" to do research in a certain way. It lists what problems need to be investigated and how the research should proceed. Different methodologies may have different paradigms to follow. Quantitative methodology uses the positive paradigm while qualitative researchers use the critical paradigm

In contrast, a method is a specific technique to collect and gather information following the assumptions of the chosen research methodology .Researchers who choose the positivist paradigm use methods like surveys and experiments while those who choose the interpretive paradigm choose methods like focus groups, ethnography, and observation.

4.12 TYPES OF RESEARCH METHODS

4.12.1 Survey Method

The literal meaning of word survey is to look at or study something carefully. It encompasses investigation and examination. Complete study about the unknown facts is survey. A descriptive survey attempts to describe or document current conditions or attitudes i.e. to explain what exist at the moment whereas analytical survey attempts to describe and explain why situations exist. In this type of research multiple variables are generally examined to investigate research questions. A media survey is a process by which quantitative facts are collected about the media aspects of community's composition and activities. The media survey is a comparative undertaking which applies scientific method to the study.

Types of surveys:

a) General or specific surveys

b) Regular and ad-hoc surveys

c) Preliminary and final surveys

d) Census

e) Opinion polls and exit polls

In survey method, the data is collected through tools such as questionnaire, schedule or interviews. A set of questions are framed according to the objectives of the research. The questions can be

Open-ended questions

Open-ended questions give respondents freedom in answering questions and an opportunity to provide in-depth responses. The major disadvantage of these questions is that the answers require large amount of time to collect and analyze the responses

Closed-ended questions

In these questions, the respondents have to choose to reply from the list provided by the researcher and because of the greater standardisation of the questions it is easy to collect the responses and the answers can be easily quantified. The major disadvantage is that often certain responses are not included in the options. As a solution to this problem, the researcher can insert an option like 'other' so that the respondents will get opportunity to give their own respective answers.

Mixed questions

These are a combination of both open ended and closed ended questions.

4.12.2 Observation Method

Observation means viewing things with a purpose. It consists of collection of the facts which are in the direct knowledge of the investigators. Observation is the perception with a purpose. It is the process of acquiring knowledge through the use of sense organs. Types of observations:

a) Controlled

b) Uncontrolled

c) Participant

d) Non- participant

e) Case-study method

According to P.V. Young, case study is a method of exploring and analysing the life of a unit be that a person, family an institution, a cultural group or even an entire community". Goode and Hatt described it as "a way of organizing social data so as to preserve the unitary character of the social/object benefits studied". Case study is based on intensive study of comparatively fewer persons. It is a method of qualitative analysis. It aims at studying everything about something rather than something about everything.

4.12.3 Content Analysis

Berelson defined content analysis as "a research technique for the objective, systematic and quantitative description of the manifest content of communication". Content analysis is a systematic way of analysis and description of the content of communication media. It is specialized application of coding techniques. It allows for the discovery and description of focus of an individual, group, institution or social attention.

Steps in Content Analysis

There are several discrete stages in the procedure of content analysis. Following are the steps listed in sequence but they need not be followed in the order given and at times, the initial stages of analysis can be easily combined. Nonetheless, these steps may be used as a rough outline:

a) Formulation of the research question or hypothesis

b) Defining the universe

c) Selecting an appropriate sample from the population

d) Selecting and defining a unit of analysis

e) Constructing categories of content to be analyzed

f) Training coders and conducting a pilot study

g) Establishing a quantification system

h) Coding of the content according to established definitions

i) Analyzing the collected data

j) Drawing conclusions and searching for indications

4.12.4 Historical Method

Past knowledge is considered to be pre- present knowledge. In so far as anything has an anticipated history and natural development, past is properly related to the present.

Check Your Progress 3

Note: 1) Use the space provided below for your Answers.
2) Compare your answers with those given at the end of the unit.

1. What is the difference between research method and research methodology?

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2. How does review of information help in the formulation of research hypothesis and questions?

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4.13 DATA

One of the goals of scientific research in science that believes in the notion of positivism is that a researcher needs to describe the nature of the population i.e. a group or class of variables, subjects, concepts, or phenomena. In certain research studies, an entire class or group is investigated like the population counting that happens every decade. This process of examining every member in a population is called census. Studying every member of a population is costly and at times not feasible. Thus, to go ahead with the study, a sample is taken from the population. A sample is a subset of the population and represents the entire population. Even though it has appropriate size, it is inadequate for testing purposes because the results cannot be generalized to the entire population from where sample was drawn. Thus, the whole purpose of study fails as such whenever a sample is drawn from a population; researchers need a method for the estimation of the degree to which the sample differs from the population. Since a sample does not provide the exact data coming from a population, error is taken into account while interpreting research results. All research is riddled with error. Much of the source of error in the behavioral sciences is that the research is conducted with the respondents i.e. the human beings who are subject to constant change.

There are two broad types of error present in all research

a) **Sampling error-** This is the error related to the selection of a sample from a population

b) **Non-sampling error-** This is the error created by the aspects of a research study like data analysis errors, measurement errors, the influence of the research situation itself, or even error from an unknown source that can never be identified, controlled or eliminated.

The most controversial aspect regarding sampling is to determine the adequate sample size so that it is representative of the entire population and brings the preferred level of assurance in the results. This answer is difficult to answer. However, the sample selection depends on the either of these factors:

a) Purpose

b) Complexity of project

c) Amount of error tolerated

d) Time constraints involved

e) Financial constraints

f) Previous studies done on the topic

Research intended for the groundwork for giving general indications usually does not require a large sample. However, studies designed to answer significant questions or studies involving huge sum of currency or which will ultimately affect people's lives necessitate accuracy and a large sample.

Area of study

The research to be conducted has a specific area of study that can be based on the topic, location of the researcher and so on. From this area a particular sample is collected from the entire population using a suitable sampling technique.

4.14 SAMPLING TECHNIQUES

Sampling is an important part of all research which is often misunderstood by beginners in research. A sample is collected from the universe or population and if selected correctly, it can represent the characteristics, opinions and attitudes of the entire population. The most important part of sampling procedure is to avoid any kind of bias which means that each respondent should have an equal chance of being selected. A few sampling techniques to select samples for your research are given below:

4.14.1 Non-Probability or Purposive Sampling

The non-probability or purposive sampling involves purposeful collection of particular units of universe that constitute the sample. Non-probability sampling never follows the mathematical probability guidelines. When the units of population are selected due to easy access, it is known as *convenience sampling*. This can be given by an example where advertising agencies are to be taken as a sample then the researcher can select the agencies according to his convenience. At times, this type of sampling can give biased results especially when the audience is not homogeneous. There is another type of purposive sampling known as judgment sampling where the researcher uses his judgment to select the sample. This sampling is used in qualitative research where hypotheses are to be developed or relationships between variables are to be found instead of generalizing them to entire population.

Advantages

- It is easy and convenient to follow
- When the time for the research is limited, this technique is easier to be used
- This is not a costly method for sampling and can bring greater results for less cost spent

Disadvantages

- The error in sampling cannot be calculated
- The sample selected can bring biased results at times

4.14.2 Probability or Random Sampling

The technique is also known as chance sampling since each unit of the population has an equal chance of getting selected. In finite population each unit has the same probability of being selected. It is mostly used when a study is being conducted to support or refute a significant research question or a hypothesis and the results will be generalized to the population. Probability sampling generally uses some type of systematic selection procedure like lottery method or random number table so that each and every unit has an equal chance of being selected Another type of sampling known as systematic sampling is used in which every nth subject, unit, or element is selected from a population. The researcher selects a starting point randomly .Systematic samples are used frequently in mass media and save time as well as resources but its limitation is that it doesn't guarantee representative sample from the population

Advantages

- Detailed knowledge about the population is not compulsory
- External validity may be concluded statistically
- A representative group can be easily obtained
- The chances of classification error are eliminated

Disadvantages

- A list of the population has to be compiled.
- A sample that is representative may not exist in all cases and is at times more expensive than the other methods

4.14.3 Stratified Sampling

When the population is homogeneous and the sample is to be chosen to represent the population, stratified sampling is used. Homogeneity helps researchers to reduce sampling error. The population is divided or stratified into several numbers of non-overlapping strata called as subpopulations and the units are chosen from each stratum to select the sample. If the sample from the strata is selected in a random way, it is known as stratified random sampling. For example, research on the attitude towards two way cable or satellite television. The investigator would state that the respondents might have higher achievement levels to stratify the population according to education and thus divides the population into three education levels: grade school, high school, and college.

Advantages

- Relevant variables are represented.
- The other populations can be compared too.
- A homogeneous group is chosen for selection.
- Sampling error is reduced.

Disadvantages

- Prior to selection, knowledge of the population is required.
- The procedure is time-consuming and expensive and can be tricky to locate the sample when incidence is low.
- Variables defined strata may not be relevant.

4.14.4 Quota Sampling

It is a form of non-probability sampling where the units from each stratum are given different quotas to be filled and the selection of units depends upon the judgment of the researcher. The size of each quota is proportionate to the size of the strata in the population.

4.14.5 Cluster Sampling

This type of sampling involves the division of the population into various segments or clusters and taking those clusters instead of selecting individual units or the sample. The sample size must be larger than the simple random sample for better level of accuracy. Another kind of sampling known as area sampling is also used which is quite similar to cluster sampling. When the geographical area for research is large, it is divided into small clusters of non-overlapping areas and then these small areas are randomly selected. It is helpful when the list of population is unavailable. It also makes field interviewing easier as the interview can be taken at many times in the same location to analyze the media habits of people in a country the research would be complex and time consuming when individuals are selected as a sample randomly. With cluster sampling, the state can be divided into districts, or pin-code areas, and groups of people can be selected from each area.

Advantages

- Only a part of the population needs to be selected.
- Costs reduce when clusters are well elaborated and can be compared to the population.

Disadvantages

- Sampling errors may occur.
- Clusters may or may not be representing the population.
- Each unit has to be assigned to a specific cluster

4.14.6 Multi-Stage Sampling

This is sampling technique which is followed when research extends to a wide geographical area like the entire country. Thus, the stages are made and units are selected like first the states, then the districts, towns and then families. When random sampling is done at each stage, it is called as multi-stage random sampling. At times, various above given techniques are used which is called as mixed sampling. The sample design must be chosen according to the nature of the study and other related factors.

4.14.7 Questionnaire

A set of questions are framed in the questionnaires and the researcher mails them with a request to the respondents them after completion. It is widely used method for carrying out surveys. Usually a pilot study is done, before sending the questionnaires to test the weaknesses of the questionnaire. It must be framed carefully to gather data and bring effective results.

In schedule, the researchers may go or train some of enumerators to go to the respondents. They then ask questions and record their replies on the basis of the answers given by the respondents. As such the enumerators must have the ability to record the answers properly.

4.14.8 Interviews

P.V. Young said "Interview may be regarded as a systematic method by which a person enters more or less imaginatively into the life of the comparative stranger. The interview is a data collection technique that depends on verbal method of collection of data. This is a direct method of collecting data The interviews can be personal or telephonic where personal interview is more structured and face to face. Telephonic interviews are used in industrial surveys in developed regions when the time for the survey is also limited.

4.15 DATA ANALYSIS AND PRESENTATION

Rigorous analysis of the collected datais done. There are various computer tools and softwares available for this. Depending upon different types of research methods, the analysis also differs and the hypotheses are tested at this stage. There are many ways to test the hypothesis. Depending upon the nature and objectives of the research study, the test can be used to test the hypothesis. When the hypothesis is tested and replicated several times, it can lead to the formation of a theory i.e. the results can be generalized. This is the actual success of the research study conducted when the results can be generalized. When the findings are explained on the basis of some theory and there is no hypothesis to start with, then this is known as interpretation

4.16 REPORT

After the research study has been conducted; the report needs to be written. The format is given below:

4.16.1 Abstract

This is a short paragraph at the beginning of the research paper that explains the contents of the paper concisely and comprehensively. It must be accurate, self-contained and concise. It must include the basic purpose of the research study and relevant results or conclusions .

4.16.2 Keywords

These are the key terms or concepts that describe the ideas in a research. Through these words, the study can be searched in various information sources, in libraries, on the internet and so on

4.16.3 Introduction

The objectives or research questions of the research, explanation of the methodology, its scope and limitations of the study are discussed in the introductory part of the report. The hypothesis is written down with the sample size, sampling technique and research method. Thereafter, extensive review of literature is written.

4.16.4 Findings

The findings must be explained properly with charts, graphics and illustrations to suit the information presented.

4.16.5 Conclusion

This section comes in the end and includes the results. The results are put down clearly and precisely.

4.16. 6 Annexure and Appendices

All other important information like questionnaires, code sheets are included in this part towards the end of the report. A few more things to be kept in mind while writing the report. They are

APA style: The report must be written in APA style which is the most widely accepted form of report writing. APA format includes the name of the author(s) title of the source (book, journal, newspaper, magazine), name of the publisher, year of publishing, edition of publication, page number. In case it is a website, the date of retrieval is a also mentioned.

4.16.7 Bibliography/References

The references to the texts read must be given at the end of the report under the bibliography section.

4.16.8 Citations

Within the text of the report, when writing about some particular terms, the citations must be given to the references mentioned at the end of the report. These citations are given in a set of parentheses with the name of the author and the year of publication.

4.17 ETHICS IN RESEARCH

Mass media researchers must follow certain rules according to the ethical obligations to their subjects and respondents. Cook (1976), discussing the laboratory approach, offered a code of behavior to represent the norms of research ethics:

- Not to involve people in research without their knowledge or consent
- Not to force the people to participate
- Not to withhold or lie about the true nature of the research from the participant
- Not to lead the participant to commit acts that may diminish his or her self-respect
- Not to violate the right to self-determination
- Not to expose the participant to any kind of physical or mental stress
- Not to invade into the privacy of the participants
- Not to withhold benefits from participants in control groups
- Not to fail treating research participants fairly and to show them consideration and respect

Frey, Botan, and Kreps (2000) have mentioned following summarized moral principles that must be commonly advocated:

– Provide the respondents with free choice

– Protect their right to privacy

– Benefit them and do not harm them

Treat them with respect

4.18 LET US SUM UP

In this unit we explained the meaning of mass communication research. We started with the development of mass media research and importance of research objectives followed by the importance for motivation in research. We discussed about the scientific approach to mass communication and the importance for empirical generalizations.

We further discussed about the types of research and when and where they are used. We also discussed about the research approaches and the important steps to follow in research such as selection of topic to review of literature to development of hypothesis and research objectives and how the data analysis and presentation should be done. Further, we analysed the research design and the importance of ethics in research.

It is hoped that the unit will help you in understanding how to approach research in mass communication.

4.19 KEYWORDS

1) Mass Communication Research: Application of set rules to find out various aspects of mass communication.

2) Empirical Generalisation: Universal truth leading to theorisation.

3) Research Ethics: Principles of morality in research process.

4) Research Methodology: Philosophical assumptions of research.

5) Research Design: The basic framework or blue print for doing research.

4.20 FURTHER READINGS

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4.21 CHECK YOUR PROGRESS: POSSIBLE ANSWERS

Check Your Progress 1

1. Hypothesis is a supposition or proposed explanation made on the basis of limited evidence as a starting point for further investigation. It is a proposed statement which requires research for validation. It is tested to be proven either true or false.

2. It is a stage in research where a phenomenon is described based upon the knowledge of the phenomena at that point of time. These empirical generalizations are based on the observations made in the field. It is done with honesty to ensure accuracy in the data and avoid the situation of bias in the study.

3. Objectives in research help in defining what the research is focused on, what it wants to study and why it wants to study. Research objectives help in giving a concrete shape to the research. They help in defining the ways through which the research is to be conducted and what tools and techniques will help the best in completing the research.

Check Your Progress 2

1. When a research is focused on development of theory or a process which is universal, then the form of research is called fundamental research. Applied research, on the other hand, involves the use of the theories and testing them in the social settings. The development of theories always takes place in fundamental research.

2. When the research is focused on understanding the aspect of what or is dealing with numerical values and statistics, then the approach of research is quantitative as it is dealing with values and numbers. Qualitative approach is focused more on understanding the how and why aspect of research. It is more in-depth and requires critical analysis.

Check Your Progress 3

1. Methodology is a science of studying methods and deals with the question of “why” to do research in a certain way. It lists what problems need to be investigated and how the research should proceed. Different methodologies may have different paradigms to follow. Quantitative methodology uses the positive paradigm while qualitative researchers use the critical paradigm. In

contrast, a method is a specific technique to collect and gather information following the assumptions of the chosen research methodology. Researchers who choose the positivist paradigm use methods like surveys and experiments while those who choose the interpretive paradigm choose methods like focus groups, ethnography, and observation.

2. The review of information helps in understanding how much and how far the research has been done regarding a specific discipline. The review of information helps in developing an understanding about the questions that can be raised to explore newer attributes in the respective field. As a result, research hypotheses and questions cannot be formulated without proper review of information.

Check Your Progress 4

1. It divides the population into various segments or clusters for sampling. The sample must be larger for more accuracy. Thus is useful in conducting field inter views.

2. a) Take the consent of the participants before involving them in research.

   b) Do not violate their privacy.

   c) Do not cause physical or mental stress to participants in research.